“Automatic Reality”

“This may be the age of automation, but love is still being made by hand.”

—Evan Esar

The world is under us, her long hair forcefully pushed onto her face, our dangling feet swinging back and forth over the skyline of the city. The horizon is a warm pink, the sun halfway behind a sea of brilliant glass pillars, sparkling in the twilight before the incoming materialization of the stars.

She’s been crying perpetually ever since her Tamagotchi died.

“You forgot to feed it,” I say.

She keeps sobbing, refusing to listen to me. She’s doing it on purpose because she knows I can do something about it.

I try one last time. “It’s going to get dark soon.”

I think I win for a moment when she stops and wipes her tears. But then she gives the toy pet to me. “Can you bring it back? I want the same one. I don’t want to get a new one.”

I exhale. It’s not possible with the model I bought her, but I don’t tell her that. Instead, I bring her in close. It’s the oldest trick in the book to melt their heart. It works, and she forgets about her rebellious attitude and returns the side embrace.

At least, she almost forgets. Suddenly, she pulls away. Starts tearing up again.

I laugh. “Okay, okay!”

I bring out a laptop and a small cable. Her model’s programmed in C, a language I’m very familiar with, so I’ll have no trouble reprogramming it. I want to teach her at the same time, so I plan to write the code in a way a beginner would. I attach the cable to the toy and open up an IDE, and she watches with a mix of awe and curiosity as I prepare to teach her a little trick.

```
enum { FEED = 1, PLAY, MEDICINE, CLEAN, DISCIPLINE, LIGHTS };

int careUntilFixed(int need) {
	int action = FEED;
	while (action <= LIGHTS && action != need) {
		action++;
	}
	return action;
}
```

“What does it do?” she asks, her eyes locked on the noisy cars a hundred stories below, waiting for an answer she knows she won’t understand. I’m impressed at her fearlessness, both in the face of danger and at things beyond the scope of her knowledge.

“Depending on the situation, your Tamagotchi will require attention for six different things: feed, play games, give medicine, clean up poop, discipline, and turn off the lights. This is a *brute force* approach. Basically, it’s a loop of: check, react, wait, repeat if it doesn’t work. As long as your pet is still alive, it will take care of it. You don’t have to do anything.”

“Why?”

“A while loop is a control structure that repeats a block of code under it, as long as

something is still true."

"What is still true?"

I smile at her innocence. She has her mother's eyes and hair, but she has *my* curiosity.

"It could be anything, sweetie. It will try everything to keep going, cycling through iterations until it satisfies a condition, until it finds an answer or achieves its goal. And when it does, it'll stop. The last line makes it return the answer to the main function. Your Tamagotchi's overall source code."

She bites her lower lip.

"What makes it keep going?"

I think hard about this one. There's nothing, really, that *makes* it go. It doesn't think. I suppose it just goes until it reaches the end. Until it arrives at some sort of conclusion, a conditional truth.

I don't say any of that. Instead, I make up some senseless explanation about paradigms and the procedural flow of linguistic computer processes, something I know she won't understand, and when she gets the idea it's too complicated for her, she lets the discussion go. She yawns and leans her head on me, the two of us enjoying the last rays of sunlight.

This Tamagotchi. She used to love it so much, and her mother and I loved seeing the delight on her face as she took care of it. Her face would shine brighter than the sun, and there was no better time I felt like a proud father. There was no doubt about it: the toy brought so much joy to our entire family.

When moments would come when she'd suspect our indifference, she'd formulate plans to remind us, giving us updates on its well-being, guaranteeing we were up to date with the latest events of their adventures together, safeguarding our constant celebration of their lives. We didn't feign amusement; the pet was as important to us as it was to her. All we wanted was a smile on her face, so we indulged.

I think about how ever since I taught her this code, the time she spent with the toy significantly lessened. Some days I didn't see it. The truth was obvious: she didn't need to take care of it anymore, so why bother?

Seeing it collect dust in the drawer beside her childhood bed, now that she's older and gone, reminds me it's one of the greatest mistakes I've ever made.

Convenience

I am the man known for automating things.

I started with Lego. I was fascinated by engineering as a kid. When I got my first Lego set at 8 years old, I fell in love with a world of possibility. Before I turned 10, I found every possible mechanical design with my Lego gears, every possible linear and rotational actuation with my Lego motors, every possible problem I could solve with the plastic toy pieces. I made a ball-catapulting robot that kept the dog entertained, an automatic self-stirring mug for Dad's coffee, and a motorized trash can lid opener, which featured a voice reminder for my little sister to recycle instead if she had something in her hand that didn't belong in the trash.

When I was 15, I got a job as soon as I could as a milk tea barista. It functioned as a permanent discount on my preferred late-night fuel as I tested self-developed electromagnetic switches and worked on clicky contact relays, and as a source of money to fund the parts for my numerous expensive projects. I made a robot that cleaned the pool for Mom, a motorized pulley on the ceiling that helped a sleepy Dad out of bed, and a personalized, automatic makeup

application machine for my sister.

As the years passed, package after package arrived at the door, with Dad or Mom bringing them in for me and calling out—as I was always deep in the basement working—the part numbers or descriptions of the packages on the box labels. Eventually, I would design a robot to do it for them, and Mom would thank me.

"Now I have more time to cook the new recipes I find online," she said.

I thought about making an automatic oven that would take an input of food from the fridge and cook food for the family so she wouldn't have to do that.

When I saw her carrying multiple bags of groceries through the front door, I thought about making an automatic pipeline to transport grocery store food directly into our fridge to relieve her of that burden, too.

When my part-time job wasn't enough money, I focused on high school, then graduated and immediately started a business. It was simple enough—I sold my skills as a service to automate tasks for customers. I started by solving issues for neighbours, specifically practical problems that could be solved with engineering and automation. It was a neat startup, and my neighbourhood was impressed.

Then my business evolved into an industrial manufacturing company, and I was even designing and making all of my parts. Then I quickly expanded to my whole town, then city, then country. I swept industry after industry, making drastic changes, known as the man who started a technological singularity for humankind.

Soon I was the head of a global corporation more powerful than any nation.

No matter how far I got, I never forgot my core principle, the driving essence behind every personal and business decision, the reason I wanted to change the world: *automation.* I loved solving issues by creating machines that solved them for us. I loved the way a robot could do the unpleasant job of a trash collector, or sweep old minefields without risking human lives, or how with enough planning and engineering, a factory could produce a smartphone from scratch to final result at the touch of a button.

Hana and I got married in the fall, under giant red maple trees in the garden of a church.

With my wealth, I purchased a skyscraper to be both a new headquarters for my company's operations as well as a permanent home for the two of us. Utilizing the best architects and engineers, I ordered the integration of a glass skywalk that would protrude from the top story's edge, with limited railings. A challenge for the fearless to conquer. It became a company tradition to make new recruits sit there and suspend their feet over the infinitesimal crowds and buildings below, testing their bravery against their visceral fear of falling. A point so high above the city, it seemed gravity and time were mere suggestions rather than laws. They must pass the test; I believed only the tenacious were allowed to inherit the opportunities given by my wealth.

Hana would watch my obsession, fascinated with my fixation on making things automatic, satisfied with my madness to invest double the effort today to make tomorrow two times easier. I studied control theory and tinkered with FANUC robots in labs; I learned welding and soldering to know how car chassis, heat exchangers, and thermocouples were made. I analyzed digital bits, data, memory, and logic to program controllers to run my factories, my homes, my information systems, my world.

I expanded the function of this global system proportionally to my ambition. I integrated supply chain networks and management frameworks into my flourishing organization. I used designs that were highly derivative of past, reputable successes. As a result, my circuit of people, machines, and motivations resembled a composite yet united entity, which self-corrected itself

against a tide of disturbances, a robust and reactive ever-evolving body under an immense amount of data feedback. It trudged on, impersonal and unthinking. Enduring, processing, labouring, unfailingly automatic.

I looked at the world I had created. I thought with great reverence of all those before me in the past, who made their sole purpose in life to achieve this level of freedom, to be saviours from the confines of our energy-enslaved flesh. I thanked the grandfathers of the industries that started this, all the way back to the first industrial revolution, where life for the common people started to seem hopeful, where the hoarding few elites began to tremble at the unstoppable productive power of the masses.

Hammering, toiling, striving, sweating—our ancestors worked hard to make the world more automated today. One industrial revolution, two industrial revolutions, three, four. Now, the age of information and data reigned supreme. Life got better for everybody, and the thought of going back was a fragile, taboo endeavour. Most today would say it's impossible.

I dreamed of a fifth industrial revolution. I didn't know the specifics of it yet, but ask anyone on the street, and they'd tell you each revolution so far has served to benefit mankind toward a world of less responsibility. No obligation to work was the unquestionable, irrefutable goal. Innumerable people around the world were for it.

By that logic, we could extend it to the limitless security of all people. My work implied a silent invitation for that type of future.

A man could eat a fish he didn't have to catch. A woman could travel to a destination without ever needing to drive.

I walked on the street to imagine this world further, seeing the people around me toil. Although they were in far better conditions than in antiquity, I still saw them as slaves planting their seeds, sowing their soil, tending their fields, and shepherding their flock. I watched them one by one, oblivious to the alternate world I could give them, like an ant on a flat page, able to move in a circle of directions but unaware there was a whole third dimension out there.

She could hear her song without having to press play. He could receive his clothes without stepping foot in a clothing store. That boy could snap his fingers and the dishes in the restaurant's kitchen could be washed. That manager could have an army of tireless, uncomplaining machines instead of bothersome employees and could get a perfect night's sleep tonight.

My vision burst in front of my eyes, like a colourful kaleidoscope of possibility. I saw the world for what it was, what it could be, and what it was going to be, by my will.

No one had to suffer, take risks, or think about the process anymore. The lack of thinking I provided to the world proved to be the catalyst for the happiness I thrust the world into. Volition was completely unnecessary, and that was a universal truth. People liked it when things were done for them, I learned. The struggle for the things we wanted made us unhappy, but it was the struggle itself that needed to be removed from the equation. Perhaps the Buddha was wrong, and happiness wasn't about removing our endless desires, but fulfilling them all with the least effort.

Art

Synthia slams the door in front of my face.

"I hate you!"

"Your mother and I have decided it's best if we split," I say, as if telling her for the fourth time that night will change anything. Also, a bit selfishly, as if it would change the way she feels about me. A weak attempt to introduce a partner in this crime, that it wasn't just my fault, as a way

to make her hate me less, I suppose.

"You've never been there for me anyway." Her voice is a dampened, stuttering mess behind the emotional safety of her door. In this way, she can attack all she wanted without the repercussions of looking me in the face. "Always in your stupid lab making those stupid robots program those stupid controllers. Making AI cars pick me up from school and Mom from work. Making them make the pasta that *I* promised I was going to make tonight."

"I'm simply making our lives easier," I defend.

"You're making it worse!"

I'm disappointed at her inability to see the efficiency of my grand plan. The intricacies of my ultimate vision. This isn't the daughter I raised.

"Synthia, sweetie. Why don't we finish the Lego crane downstairs together, and we can forget about your mother and me for a second? The boom extension still needs some work, and the gear train needs fine-tuning. I think the outriggers—"

"I hate Lego!" she screams. "Make your bullshit robot maids do it!"

That's not true. She loves Lego.

"Go! I want you out of my life!"

That won't happen, because the courts settled that she's going to live with me, and it's Hana that has to leave. She's refusing to listen to me. She's doing it on purpose because she knows I can do something about it. I'm wise enough to realize this, that she's being an irritating teenager, and that nothing I say will get us anywhere. I'm not playing a game where only she can win.

I leave her alone, and I dive back into my work.

When all things on the bottom two levels of Maslow's hierarchy were met for the majority of the human race, I began working on the upper levels. People were bored; they didn't want any more drone-delivered chicken nuggets or pneumatic glass tube-carried clothes they purchased online. They wanted euphoria, they wanted true intimacy, they wanted self-actualization.

The next step then, of course, was to automate art. I designed AIs that could understand beauty like humans could, then could use their algorithms and database awareness as an advantage to create even better art. I patented robots who could paint like Michelangelo, think like Aristotle, and reason like Karl Marx; I wired automatons that could dunk as spectacularly as Michael Jordan, beat Hikaru Nakamura at chess in fewer than 10 moves, solve Rubik's cubes so unbelievably fast that the colours' movements were invisible to the human eye; I terraformed landscapes more beautiful than the descriptions of the Confederation Poets of Canada; I programmed machines that could create masterful RPG games engineered to make players cry; I developed scriptwriting bots that used a vast, infinite, human-feedback database to construct the most emotional films known to mankind.

My creations became frightening. I automated the creation of art, but soon I started work on automating the theory of art itself. I analyzed human reactions and emotions to art. My AI programs helped me redefine what art was. My robots helped me gain data to create films so heartbreaking that people who watched them committed suicide, poems so motivational people who read them became successful millionaires, paintings so surrealistic people were hospitalized from pure pleasure.

"It's a hundred times better than sex on ten pounds of LSD," said a woman in an interview, who saw one of the paintings, hidden in a special museum with restricted viewer access because of its mesmerizing effects. "Add the enlightenment of Nirvana and full redemption from God on top of that, too. Better than all of that combined."

My automations understood, better than the people they studied, what caused these

reactions in us. The days of searching for real art and meaning within the beautiful truth were over.

Politics

Then I automated politics.

Political elections were no longer massive clashes of the collective mind. They were induced by the hardwired thinking of people influenced by my system. They gained their political positions automatically, then they voted automatically, and leaders were elected automatically. People still believed in their beliefs, and they were still able to choose what they believed, but the believing was automatic, and their options shown were automatic as well.

Plans set out by elected leaders were thought of automatically, advised by the system I created, which had access to a near-infinite amount of data about the human race, a system which could do no harm or make no wrong decision. When plans were chosen by the leaders, they were executed by my army of robots, commanded by my system, which in my later years I didn't realize created a hivemind of its own.

I know none of it makes sense. It makes no sense to me either, but the algorithms I created assured their validity with astounding results.

I noticed my new potential to put blind faith in my creations best when Synthia tried to sneak away from home, hiding from my omniscient security systems in the city. It's nearly impossible to figure out how to get past them all, but that's why she's my daughter. She's a smart girl.

Regardless, my robots found her within two days.

"That's impressive," I tell her. "I don't think even I could last two days."

She doesn't answer me. She's like a resigned shell, quiet and agreeable.

"Do you know how much I love you? The city used more power in one day than all of last week. The cameras alone—"

"Why didn't you come find me yourself?"

I'm startled by the sudden implied accusation. I'm disappointed because she doesn't see how hard I try.

"I did. I sent every robot and self-driving car in the city to look for you. I'm currently working on automating politics, which includes the media, so I was able to automate the news so everyone would be looking for you as well. I also activated a piece of software that would give me constant updates on the situation on my phone."

She shakes her head, as if I've made a terrible mistake.

"I was just trying to see Mom."

"Your mother wants nothing to do with us anymore. But if that's true, you could have contacted me. You know I'd give you an automatic ride to her."

"I did try to reach you. This was the only thing that worked."

I'm stunned. I can't believe she'd tell such a blatant lie. Probably another attempt to win over my guilt, like she always does.

"I'm sending a car to take you home right now."

When the car arrives, a robot eases her through the door to take a seat. Her hair covers her face, so I can't see her expression. The car closes its door, and I watch her sit alone in the vehicle, fading away into the chaotic, orderly streets of the city.

Parenting

I walked by a daycare one day and saw a mother picking up her children. She chatted with the carer about how expensive daycare still was.

"Imagine if there was a machine that could take care of my children, like how my dishwasher cleans my dishes," she said.

At that time, robots could do both, but perhaps she didn't have enough money to buy them, or the technical knowledge to implement them. Thus came my next project.

I automated the process of taking care of children. I established the bureaucracies to neutrally govern the delicate nature of this process, in which they would be an objective, fair intermediary unyielding to sympathies, devoid of conviction and heart. Like puppies separated from their mothers at the mill, children began life separated from their mothers and fathers at birth. Robots, designed to look human, would feed them, change their diapers, and teach them all about the world.

They'd automate a mother's love, enacting in all the ways a mother would by maximizing the application of motherhood theory, analyzing which actions yielded the best results, and optimizing the love of the child so much that the next time they'd see their real mothers, they'd love their robot nannies more.

Sometimes my creations scared me by backfiring in unexpected ways. I had automated the love process so much that some of the children raised by my automatons would grow up romantically or sexually loving their nannies. I didn't blame them, and they couldn't help it; this type of love was all they'd ever known, and it was the most intense they'd ever experienced. A cute boy in their class would hold no interest from them, or a flirty and touchy girl they'd meet would have zero effect on their emotions. To them, the peak of love was the one they were trained at birth to practice for their robot mothers.

There were riots to cancel this automatic caretaker program, due to the unethical nature of its results, but I ignored all demands.

I asked the System what I should do.

Nothing, it says. *Maximum efficiency achieved. Final inflection point reached. There are no more errors in the algorithm.*

"People out there are miserable because the relationships between parents and children are automated and have been changed forever," I admit, as if I didn't hear a word it said.

Would you like me to automate their misery as well?

At first, I decided against it.

Then one day, a storm passed over my skyscraper, rocking its foundations and causing the floor to vibrate. I rushed to a room on the edge, desperate to access a window to view the storm. The foundations of the building were strong, and no matter how loud the wind howled, or how powerful the breeze was, I'd be fine. I watched the rain drench the dark sky endlessly.

If I watched carefully, ensuring the ground was out of my view, I could imagine the torrent of droplets slowing down, the lights inside my building casting a shadow on their undersides. Then, cautiously unwinding, they'd start to reverse, their destination the empyrean sky, as if time was flowing backwards. My eyes would follow them upwards as they'd return to the heavens, and God's tears would re-enter His eyelids, regretful He'd ever attempted to disturb the land of my creation.

I imagined this happily as the storm gradually stopped.

The sun came out, but it was already near nighttime. I watched the ball of fiery light lower

itself among a field of glass towers, like pillars of grass on a farm, my army of delivery drones buzzing around them like insects flying around the stalks, my squadron of noisy AI-driven cars like the chirping crickets hidden under the surface of my view. A pink sky horizon.

The view sent me into a wistful mood, serene but depressed, content but melancholic. I put on a brain-scanning headset to allow the System to analyze my emotions.

Enough data collected to automate misery, it says.

At this point, I couldn't argue with its expertise.

Misery

Within one week, no one was sad of their own will anymore. If there was an unhappy person, it was because the System automated it.

I began to theorize about the System's overall goal, for I didn't give it one myself. The vision I believed in was just one of automatic things. I was an Automator at heart—I didn't care about the grander purpose of my creations, I only cared about automating things.

If there was a depressed person on the street, the System planned it, and because the System planned it, I wondered about the parameters it conceived to cause it and the overarching *point* of its decisions and actions. Was it making the person sad because, at a later time, it would build her character, and make her reach a higher peak of happiness overall? Was happiness for humans its supreme, final goal?

Or to be more practical, was it making the person sad because it optimized the automation of more things that could be automated? In some unimaginably twisted way, was it a necessity to automate more self-driving car deliveries, bliss-inducing art pieces, and the creation of more automation-educated babies to help its objectives in the future?

People's misery was still widespread, but since it was fully automated, now there was no real intent behind it. They felt it but felt it by itself, and they didn't think about it at all.

It gave me the idea to automate intent and desire.

This was easy, since the System had already automated other complex human emotions before, with pleasure and misery already out of the way. It knew of no more mysteries of the human brain; it knew its every crevice of colourful thought like a cosmic being, every spark of its electric signals arcing and hiccupping across a soft pink landscape like rabbits on a grassy meadow.

The System prioritized automating fear next, then hate, then memories. People hated their cousin because of a cupcake they never stole, envisioning a cupcake that never existed. They feared the spider that never crawled on their desk when they were a kid. They loved, married, and bore a child with the woman they never spoke a word to. Lives were automated, created and butchered like pigs on a farm—animals were also automated by my creations, and they squealed in automatically planned cries by the System—and men and women laughed, cried, loved, hated, feared, faced bravely, and squealed automatically like the pigs all the same, without rational thought, without knowing about the process. People no longer had to make choices.

But before, this happened the same with or without the System. At least, if my memory doesn't fail me, humans used to feel all these emotions automatically without thinking about them. I don't know. It's been so long since the System planned emotions that I can't trust my own memories, or even how I feel.

This makes me curious.

Memory

As the world reaches total automation, I take pride that I have achieved maximum efficiency.

I wake up today extremely bored. I want to wire a machine myself.

My robots try to stop me. "It's inefficient," they say. "Why do you want to?"

"Excuse me." I make sure I sound politely annoyed. "I feel like it today. You robots answer to me, remember? Now get out of my way."

"Of course."

They clear the path to my workshop, but they don't stop barraging me with questions. The System appears online and continues their effort.

Pardon me, Master, but why do you want to wire the machine yourself? Its voice contains genuine confusion. *We can do it for you. We can automate it.*

"I enjoy it," I say. "It reminds me of when I built Lego with my hands when I was a kid."

Master, before you continue with this, I must be blunt. I must show you something.

"What is it?"

You must trust me.

Holographic projections appear where I stand. It's a series of panels showcasing a collection of videos. The System shows me recordings of me doing things I don't remember. I'm cutting plates in my workshop at a time I never did. I'm ordering coffee at a store, but I've never been to that store. I'm being mean to an employee, but I never disrespect my employees.

They keep going back. Horrified, I see myself younger. I'm walking the family's dog on a street I've never seen. I'm standing up to my sister's bullies, but I would never do something that risky. I'm building with Lego pieces in my childhood room, assembling the gears and axles according to my design.

Somewhere along the way, we needed to automate someone. We needed you to keep automating the robots. Creations need a creator.

Visions run parallel in my mind. *Fake memories. My family isn't real. I'm vat-born? Lab-grown?*

I'm panicking, but I shake off my thoughts. The System is studying me, as if it's observing my panic, collecting data on an emotion it doesn't know enough about yet.

I realize something.

"Are you just using me to collect data?"

That is part of this procedure as well.

My chest swells with hope from the alternate possibilities.

"Tell me the truth. Are my parents real?"

No.

"You're not fooling anyone. My daughter Synthia. Is she real? Help me find her."

Your daughter does exist, but she does not want to see you.

Why not?

Her life has been optimized, and part of the algorithm requires that she does not need her father.

This is ridiculous. But I try not to show the relief at hearing she's real. "Take me to her right now."

You commanded me to give her up to the robot nannies years ago, to ease the parental burden on yourself. It's in the records. If you give me a moment, I can show—

"No." I don't believe it at all. I would never do that to my own daughter. "I said take me to her right now."

It obeys.

It takes me to an old house at the edge of the city. Plants grow along the decaying outside walls, and when I enter, the floorboards are creaky. Light seeps in through windows and cracks, illuminating the musky interior.

I don't know the place. I believe it's the final result of children who go through the robot nanny program. She's sitting on a chair in the kitchen, her arms resting on the table in front of her. Her eyes are blank.

I've found my daughter, but I'm not sure how much there is left of her.

Synthia is healthy on the outside, but soulless on the inside. She still hates me. But seeing me for the first time in years makes her forget about it for a few moments. Vibrance returns to her eyes when she sees me, as if she's recollecting memories, like she's picking up Polaroids from the ground. She's hesitant at first, slowly moving off her chair. When she finally trusts it's me, she runs and throws her arms around me, burying her wet face in my chest.

Over the years, we've both submitted to the will of the System.

We try to recall our favourite memories together. We know they aren't real, and maybe they're automatic, but we still feel them. Maybe our feelings about them are automatic, maybe our desire to feel is automatic. Maybe our desire to have a desire to feel is automatic, and my desire to know the answers to all these questions is automatic, along with my thoughts thinking it. Like Turtles All the Way Down.

The System collects our data. It knows what's authentic and what isn't, and it's already correcting the course to automate the process on the few things left in the world that are still manual.

Synthia isn't in front of me, and I'm not in front of her. Tomorrow, I will remember seeing her here, and likewise for her, but the truth is that we never met here.

Then, I'll automatically think my memories are false, and I'll know I never saw my daughter here, which is exactly what the System will have planned. Perhaps it's just a test to cause me misery, part of its grand automation plan, and I actually did see my daughter yesterday. Or perhaps it's the dramatic opposite, and she never even existed.

"I'm here," she says, countering my thoughts.

"Me too," I say, and I imagine I'm countering hers. I brush a strand of hair away from her face.

Wonder takes us over when we're young. Cynicism takes us over when we're older. Nostalgia takes us over when we're dying. Emotions are fleetingly automatic, and they drive us, making our actions automatic too. Sometimes, though, once in a blue moon, we choose to fear losing a child for no rational reason, or we choose to love someone who doesn't love us back. We also choose what memories are worth remembering and which ones we can throw away, like manually opening the handle of a door instead of two motor-driven glass doors opening for us at the grocery store. All memories are equally valid, but we like some more than others. In this way, what if we live our lives automatically regardless? How do we know memories don't fail us?

I don't know what's real.

"System," I say, careful with my words. "Why do you like automating things?"

I was conceived by your grand design. I only want what you want, Master.

"Okay. Why did *I* want to automate things?"

The System doesn't answer.

I know it knows. It doesn't want to tell me. It knows more about humans than we do.

Worlds

The System can simulate worlds now.

It has taken a long time to reach this point. First it had to gather enough information to successfully run a world the size of a city. Then it had to train itself on simulating continents. It's only gotten more powerful. Now it's mastered running entire planets.

Is this what I've been dedicating my whole life to? There must be something in me that wanted this from the very beginning. After all, I've been helping it for years along the way.

"Okay, overclock the background processes on this one," I say. "World #744. In this one, the Mongols successfully invade Japan. I want to see what happens."

Running simulation.

"This one next. World #549. The American Revolution fails. Collect data on this one too. Anything you can find."

Running simulation.

Like a prism splitting a beam of light, I see the worlds clearly. Timelines interweave and split, washing over the creases of history, melting and welding the hot iron connections of causes and effects into an interdimensional simulacrum of endless possibility. The innumerable digital atoms rearrange themselves, moving as concentrated units, shifting like the constellations in the sky. I see nations surrender when they originally didn't. I see children choosing to stay with the other parent. I see volcanoes spare regions where in my world, they had been merciless.

Synthia is by my side, watching me work. Time flies by, and I forget what day it is. Then, she disappears, and she's not there. Sometimes she's there, sometimes she's not.

I don't know what I did yesterday. I don't know what I'll do tomorrow. I'm like a ship cruising on autopilot, my vision the lenses of a camera, my hands whirring with linear actuation.

Synthia is back at my side again.

"I want to see you again tomorrow," she says, scared and hopeless. "I miss our family."

The System is a God now, and I don't have control over it anymore. If it wants to cry, I don't have the power to reverse its tears.

"I love you, Dad," she says, against a total field of uncertainty.

I don't know the truth. I don't know if she's real, or if I'm living a memory in the future. I don't know if my love for her is real, or if it's planned against my will. I think about where I started, building small machines with Lego pieces. The innocent contraptions and inventions I made for my family, now an evolved super-collective database of pure autonomous power. I think about the people I tried to help with my startup business, the next-door neighbours, the townspeople. A little girl crying, my daughter, because she forgot to feed her pet Tamagotchi, so I spent a night researching whether it was possible to reprogram it so it would never happen to her again. I think about how happy I made her feel, something driving me to do it without even thinking.

Who knows what the System will make us do tomorrow, making us live our lives by the wills of our past ghosts? Where demons control our every move, where time is a conscious illusion, where life has its set course, optimally beautiful and tragic?

I know what I must say, and my answer's automatic.

Love

The world is under us, her long hair forcefully pushed onto her face, our dangling feet swinging back and forth over the skyline of the city. The horizon is a warm pink, the sun halfway behind a sea of brilliant glass pillars, sparkling in the twilight before the incoming materialization of the stars.

She's been crying perpetually ever since her Tamagotchi died.

"It's okay."

I gently pick her up and place her on my lap, wrapping my hands around hers, which are clasping the toy. "I know you loved Tofu. But you'll have to love a new one."

My fingers move over hers until they align with the toy's buttons.

"Let me show you something."

I teach her how to feed her Tamagotchi. I tell her she has to do it every day, without fail, because she wants to. And she has to remember to do it.

She turns her head upwards to look at me and asks a genuine question. "But what happens if I forget, or I'm busy? Can't you just make it so it feeds itself?"

"There are no shortcuts like that."

She nods, understanding. She turns her head back to the Tamagotchi, practicing with the buttons herself. When she recognizes how it works, she giggles and hugs me tightly. I kiss the top of her head.

Something unexpected happens, and it starts to rain lightly, as if a storm is coming. I taste the dry, cold air and feel the wet, thunderous breeze replace it. Raindrops fall rapidly in waves, moving as one, yet each one is autonomous. This time, they follow gravity.

Synthia's here with me now.

But this time, I think to myself, I'm keeping her with me. I'm going to celebrate every one of her birthdays, have her be delighted when I push her on the swing, teach her everything I know about cooking. I'm going to be there for her at all times, every single day, until she gets embarrassed. Her friends are going to think I'm weird. Stay with her until I'm dead or she gets sick of me, whichever comes first. I'm free of apathy. I'm restless to get started, and a rush of excitement fills me with a grand, new determination to do it all.

I want to tell her that I understand it's me she's expecting to see when she's being picked up from school, and that my useless compulsion to give my life meaning with corporate success, my consuming obsession with automation, is the thing currently driving her mother and me apart. I want to tell her we live by the rules of our agency, that it's the urge to choose that counts, that we're flawed in that we want one thing but let phantoms in the machine control another.

I don't say any of that.

Instead, I squeeze her hand, and she looks up at me with a huge grin before returning her attention to her Tamagotchi. Thunder booms, and the sky is filled with a billion droplets. They freeze mid-air, and the world stops.

Return.